

“I Have No Idea What I’m Doing” Is the Wrong Diagnosis

Figure out what kind of problem you’re actually having.

THE IDEA

“I have no idea what I’m doing” is emotionally accurate and clinically useless. It collapses seven very different problems into one verdict. You’d never let a client stop at “everything is terrible.” You’d slow it down and ask what specifically. Give yourself the same assessment.

SEVEN PROBLEMS THAT FEEL IDENTICAL

Knowledge gap	I genuinely don’t know enough yet, and I need training or consultation.
Practice gap	I understand it but haven’t used it enough for it to feel available.
Confidence gap	I know enough to act, but I want a guarantee this can’t give me.
Activation	Something in me is making it harder to reach what I already know.
Systems problem	My caseload, supervision, or workplace is asking too much of one person.
Boundary problem	I’m holding responsibility for an outcome I can’t control.
Scope concern	This is outside my current role, and slowing down is the responsible move.

WHY IT MATTERS

Each of those needs a different response. “I suck” produces shame and no plan. “I need consultation about treatment fit” produces a phone call. Naming the category is what turns a bad feeling into a next step.

You cannot choose the right response if you misdiagnose the problem.